

Velarion Company Intelligence

REIT Executive and Board Changes Report — September 2025

September marked a period of significant leadership transition across the REIT sector, with nine executive changes spanning eight companies as organizations continue to adapt their leadership structures in the evolving real estate landscape. The month was highlighted by Christian H. Hillabrant's appointment as President and CEO of Crown Castle International following his tenure at Vantage Towers AG, alongside several notable CFO transitions including Derek Bunker's promotion at CareTrust REIT and Stephen Bakke's move from Realty Income to Postal Realty Trust. These strategic appointments and departures reflect ongoing efforts by REIT management teams to strengthen operational capabilities and position their organizations for future growth opportunities.

9 executive changes across 8 REIT companies: 5 appointments and 4 departures.

New Appointments

BRST — Broad Street Realty, Inc

▲ Jeffery C. Walraven — Chair of the Audit Committee

replacing Jeffrey H. Foster as Chair of the Audit Committee.

"Jeffery C. Walraven was appointed as Chair of the Audit Committee at Broad Street Realty, Inc., effective September 3, 2025, replacing Jeffrey H. Foster who resigned. The appointment is for an indefinite term until resignation or removal. No compensation details were disclosed in this board appointment announcement."

Source: 8-K announcement.

[8-K Filing](#)

CCI — Crown Castle Inc (\$39.4B)

▲ Christian H. Hillabrant — President and CEO

Effective: September 15, 2025 | From: Vantage Towers AG

Age 59. formerly CEO and Chairman of the Management Board at Vantage Towers AG. replacing Daniel K. Schlanger (Interim President and CEO).

Base Salary: \$1,000,000 annually

Bonus Target: 200% of base salary under 2025 EMT Annual Incentive Plan, pro-rated for 2025

Equity: 2025 Annual RSUs worth ~\$5.25M (40% time-based vesting over 3 years, 60% performance-based vesting February 2028); Make-whole RSUs worth ~\$7M vesting over 3 years; 2026 target Annual RSUs expected at \$10.5M; special vesting provisions for make-whole RSUs in severance scenarios

Signing Bonus: \$800,000 one-time cash bonus, subject to 12-month clawback

Severance: Two times the sum of base salary and annual bonus, plus continued health and welfare benefits for two years

Change-in-Control: Enhanced protections referenced in severance agreement

Clawback: Make-whole bonus subject to recoupment if voluntary termination or termination for cause within 12 months

"Crown Castle appointed Christian Hillabrant as President and CEO effective September 15, 2025, with a comprehensive compensation package including \$1M base salary, 200% bonus target, and significant equity awards totaling approximately \$12.25M in RSUs for 2025. The 59-year-old telecommunications infrastructure veteran brings over 30 years of experience, most recently as CEO of Vantage Towers AG. His package includes enhanced severance protections and make-whole provisions designed to compensate for forfeited

compensation from his previous role."

Source: 8-K announcement. Full employment agreement not yet filed.

[8-K Filing](#)

CTRE — CareTrust REIT, Inc (\$8.9B)

▲ Derek Bunker — Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer

Effective: January 1, 2026 | From: the Company

Age 37. formerly Chief Investment Officer, Executive Vice President and Secretary at The Pennant Group. replacing William M. Wagner, Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer.

Base Salary: \$475,000

Bonus Target: \$700,000 short-term incentive target for 2026 based on performance metrics

Equity: \$750,000 long-term incentive target for 2026 split between time-based and performance-based equity awards

"Derek Bunker, 37, was appointed CFO and Treasurer of CareTrust REIT effective January 1, 2026, succeeding retiring CFO William Wagner. His compensation package includes a \$475,000 base salary, \$700,000 short-term incentive target, and \$750,000 long-term equity incentive target, totaling approximately \$1.925 million in potential annual compensation. Bunker brings extensive healthcare REIT experience as former CIO of The Pennant Group and has been serving as CareTrust's SVP of Strategy and Investor Relations since June 2025."

Source: 8-K announcement. Full employment agreement not yet filed.

[8-K Filing](#)

PSTL — Postal Realty Trust, Inc (\$632M)

▲ Stephen Bakke — Executive Vice President, Chief Financial Officer

From: Realty Income Corp

Age 40. formerly Senior Vice President, Corporate Finance at Realty Income Corp. replacing Jeremy Garber (interim Chief Financial Officer).

Base Salary: \$275,000

Bonus Target: 2025: \$100,000 guaranteed cash bonus; 2026+: 110% of base salary target annual incentive bonus

Equity: \$500,000 Bonus Deferral Amount into AOI Program with 8-year cliff vest from hire date, vesting December 31, 2026 for program eligibility and November 5, 2033 for actual LTIP units/restricted stock. 2026+: target 120% of base salary in long-term incentive awards. Eligible for employee stock purchase plan and AOI Program allowing up to 100% cash compensation deferral into LTIP units or restricted stock.

"Postal Realty Trust appointed Stephen Bakke as EVP and CFO at \$275,000 base salary plus significant equity incentives. Bakke brings strong REIT experience from Realty Income Corp and Site Centers Corp. His compensation includes a \$100,000 guaranteed 2025 bonus, \$500,000 deferred equity with 8-year cliff vesting, and ongoing targets of 110% bonus and 120% equity awards. Total 2025-2026 compensation package approaches approximately \$1 million including equity components."

Source: 8-K announcement. Full employment agreement not yet filed.

[8-K Filing](#)

RLJ — RLJ Lodging Trust (\$1.3B)

▲ Nikhil Bhalla — Senior Vice President, Chief Financial Officer and Treasurer

From: the Company (internal promotion)

Age 51. formerly Vice President, Equity Research at FBR Capital Markets & Co.. replacing Leslie D. Hale as interim principal financial officer.

Base Salary: \$425,000 annually, subject to annual review and may be increased but not decreased

Bonus Target: 75% of base salary based on executive and company performance objectives, paid by March 15 following year earned

Equity: Eligible for stock options, restricted shares, restricted share units, and LTIP units in Operating Partnership with

time-based vesting. Unvested time-based equity accelerates upon non-renewal of agreement (excluding Special Awards) unless executive declines renewal or standard agreement terms.

Severance: Varies by termination type - includes severance payments and/or benefits upon termination

Non-Compete: 12 months following expiration or termination of employment

"RLJ Lodging Trust promoted 10-year company veteran Nikhil Bhalla to CFO with a new employment agreement running through September 2029. The package includes \$425,000 base salary with 75% target bonus opportunity (\$318,750 target), plus ongoing equity awards. Bhalla brings extensive REIT and hospitality industry experience, having progressed through multiple finance and treasury roles at RLJ since 2015, with prior experience at FBR Capital Markets covering REITs and Host Hotels & Resorts in strategic analysis."

Source: Employment agreement + 8-K announcement.

[8-K Filing](#) | [Employment Agreement](#)

Departures

AMT — American Tower Corporation (\$90.0B)

▼ Olivier Puech — Executive Vice President and President, International

Effective: January 2, 2026

[8-K Filing](#)

KRG — Kite Realty Group Trust (\$5.6B)

▼ Dave Buell — Senior Vice President, Chief Accounting Officer

Effective: November 21, 2025

[8-K Filing](#)

RLJ — RLJ Lodging Trust (\$1.3B)

▼ Leslie D. Hale — Interim Principal Financial Officer

[8-K Filing](#)

UDR — UDR, Inc (\$14.3B)

▼ Joseph D. Fisher — President and Chief Investment Officer

Effective: September 2, 2025

[8-K Filing](#)

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